Human Resource

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INT. OFFICE - NIGHT

RINGING rattles off glass meeting rooms hued in greens and reds. But no Team Members are at their desks.

Not that they're really *theirs*.

RING

Hüm Automations features an open-plan office, with a range of flexible spaces for both Work *and* Life...

...a snack-stocked kitchen, a sage-scented meditation room, and a black marble coffee bar with a barista named Kevin.

RING

But it's too late for Kevin now. And the kitchen's closed.

Yet BASS THUMPS the floors. Punctured only by--

RINGING

from behind rows of lush bamboo, where sleek white standing desks are empty. Except, of course:

SHAE'S DESK

with its motivational sticky notes and pinned polaroids of Team Members embracing at corporate retreats...

...and the Cisco 7800 shrieking its industry-leading:

RING--

SHAE (29, accessible in a company fleece) snaps it up.

SHAE
HR, this is--

RAM (PHONE)
Shae.

The voice ripples down her spine.

RAM (PHONE) (CONT'D)
I know what you're doing.

She swirls her chair to scan the office...

...but it's empty.

As she spins back--

Her laptop SNAPS shut.

RAM, the 40ish Chief Operating Officer, looms over her.

RAM (CONT'D)
Time to go.

She opens her mouth to protest.

But he just shakes his head and turns away...

...then bends forward. She exhales.

Then hops on his back for a piggyback ride down the hall.

RAM (CONT'D)
Relax. You've practiced enough.
You're gonna crush it tomorrow.

BASS becomes MUSIC as Ram opens the door to a:

PARTY

with a bountiful buffet, a bouncing dance floor, and a gaggle of buzzed TEAMMATES. And on stage:

GUS HÜM (Founder & CEO) pacing in plain black.

GUS
--founded this company with one simple idea: that our tools will make us *more human* - not less.

At the buffet, THE PARTNER (60s, cargo shorts, woven belt) gnashes buffalo wings. Teeth ripping red flesh from the bone.

GUS (CONT'D)
That software can handle the noise, so people can do the work.
(catching Partner's eye)
And that's only possible with the continued support of Olympus Capital. So, thank you.

The Partner returns a saucy smile, hands a clean bone to his hulking CONSULTANT beside him. Licks his fingers.

GUS (CONT'D)
And thank you to everyone here. Because the real value of this place isn't products. It's *people*.

The Partner stops licking.

Down the buffet, Shae discreetly wraps shrimp in a napkin.

SHAE'S DESK - MINUTES LATER

Shae pops open her laptop, revealing a PowerPoint deck (ShaeValue.ppt). Slides detailing 8 years of contributions and a convincing case for promotion to Vice President.

She digs into the shrimp. And clicks through the slides.

Each CLICK advancing a slide.

Each slide a moment of her evening in an **OPENING SEQUENCE:**

- CLICK. Shae reviews her bio page.
- CLICK. Shae prints 12 copies.
- CLICK. A wheel rotates slowly.
- CLICK. Exercise bike. Going nowhere. Deck propped on bar.
- CLICK. Shae washes her face.
- CLICK. Shae drops her head on a pillow.
- CLICK. Shae turns off the lights.

SEQUENCE ENDS as she straps on her sleep-mask.

Shae turns over. Sinks into the pillow. Drifting off, until--

DING!

Shae sits up, confused. Peels off the sleep-mask.

Carefully tiptoes to the door...

...and cracks it, peeks out to the:

MAIN FLOOR

of the OFFICE just as--

Gus jumps off the elevator.

He zips by a door marked MEDITATION ROOM but doesn't see:

Shae peering through the crack, from inside.

MEDITATION ROOM

Once he's out of sight, Shae exhales.

Through the door, a sliver of light shines on the front page of her deck, just the middle chunk of her title (Head of Human Resources), illuminating:

HUMAN RESOURCE

GUS'S OFFICE

Gus scrambles in, huffing and puffing. And finds:

THE PARTNER (O.S.)
Party's over, Gus.

The Partner at his desk, licking an ice cream cone.

And the mammoth Consultant on the sofa.

THE PARTNER (CONT'D)
It was a cute speech. But you know this new product is the only reason Olympus invested in this company. Everything else is replaceable.
(lick)
Especially you.

The Consultant rises. Gus tries to stop trembling.

GUS
There is no product without me.

THE PARTNER
Not yet.

The Consultant LOCKS the door behind Gus.

BLOOD DRIPS

as rare steak is sliced the next morning.

INT. OFFICE - KITCHEN - DAY

REVEAL steak being sliced in the breakfast taco buffet.

Shae joins two female JAMIES in line.

JAMIE 1
Morning Shae Shae!

JAMIE 2
Morning Shae Shae!

SHAE
Morning, Jame James.

JAMIE 1
Today the day?

Shae shrugs, coy, as they walk the taco line.

JAMIE 2
You hear about Laura?

SHAE
Laura O?

JAMIE 2
No, Laura with the--

Jamie gestures to her face area. *Ohh.*

JAMIE 2 (CONT'D)
Yeah. BetaWave just made her VP.

SHAE
Good for her. Like, *really* good.
(slabbing on steak)
Especially for her. You know, I basically taught her everything. And honestly--
(overstuffing tortilla)
--she wasn't even that good.

JAMIE 2
Good enough to be a Vice President.

SHAE
Yeah. Pulling 80 hours a week.

JAMIE 1
Looks like she's at the beach.

Jamie 1 checks Instagram. Shae peers over her shoulder.

SHAE
Wish I could just *go to Italy.* But people actually kind of need me.

Four eyes roll as--

DARA (O.S.)
Shae? I need you.

See? Shae takes a big satisfied bite.

SHAE'S DESK - MINUTES LATER

Shae focuses on her PowerPoint. Meanwhile, baby associate DARA (23, sleeves over wrists) stands at her shoulder.

Behind them, the WHITE BOARD reads:

Q1: <u>LEAN IN</u>

DARA
--and he was weird about it. Like *I* was being weird. So should I talk to him again? Or is *that* weird?

SHAE
It's only weird if you're weird. And you're not weird, Dara. You're a badass *adult* woman who knows what she's doing.

DARA
Right. And what am I doing?

Dara lifts a thumbnail to her teeth - but Shae pulls it away without even looking.

DARA (CONT'D)
Please just tell me what to do. I don't wanna get yelled at again.

SHAE
(halting, not turning)
Wait. He *yelled* at you?

DARA
I just said that.

SHAE
No. You said he was weird about it.
(typing again with force)
That he made you feel like *you* were being weird. But you never said that he *yelled* at you...Dara...

Shae stabs Ctrl+S and swings to Dara. Gently:

SHAE (CONT'D)
...did he yell at you?

ZEKI (PRE-LAP)
I asked her to do her job.

ZEKI'S DESK

Shae patiently sits with the impatiently coding ZEKI (30s).

SHAE
Right. But the thing is, that's not *your* job. If you have concerns with an HR associate, you come to me.

ZEKI
I'm not concerned about your mini-me, Shae. I'm concerned about...*me*.

SHAE
Why? Ram said you're irreplaceable.

ZEKI
Everyone is replaceable. You know what we build here.
(turning, vulnerable)
And I can't lose this job.

Shae follows his nervous eyes to a framed photo of his family in Turkey. She overdoes a sympathetic sigh.

SHAE
Listen, I get it--

ZEKI
No. You don't. You work here because you *can*. I work here because I'm *temporarily permitted*. If I don't get another H-1B...

SHAE
Zeki. If the company promised you a Green Card, they'll handle it.

ZEKI
But you basically *are* this company, Shae. Why can't you handle it?

SHAE
Because that's above my head.

She smirks. *For now.* Then struts off. Leaving Zeki confused.

COFFEE BAR

Hunky barista KEVIN preps an iced latte for an incoming Shae.

SHAE
My angel. Can you actually make it hot for me?

KEVIN
But you're already on fire.

She blushes. He proceeds to foam her milk.

SHAE
I didn't see you at the party.

KEVIN
Oh I thought that was for like, *actual* employees.

SHAE
Kevin. You're part of the family.

He smiles. Sure. Then finishes decorating the foam. Meanwhile, on her phone, Shae checks messages with NINA. Scrolls to a photo: a DAD with a teen girl. At the beach.

KEVIN
Is that your sister?

SHAE
Half.
(under breath)
The new and improved model.

KEVIN
(sliding her the latte)
There's taro buns in the kitchen. If you haven't had your yogurt yet.

SHAE
What would I do without you?

KEVIN
Spend less time in the office?

She SNORTS foam. *Funny*.

CONFERENCE ROOM

Shae's setting PowerPoint decks, muffins on the table when--

THE DOOR OPENS violently.

SHAE
Ram?

Ram collapses onto the sofa. Phone falls to the floor.

SHAE (CONT'D)
Are you seriously hungover?

RAM
Shae. It's a bloodbath.

SHAE
Well then stop doing coke with Grady! This is a huge meeting for me. Gus is about to be here.

RAM
(shaking head gravely)
Gus is officially *persona non grata*.

SHAE
Is that in Italy?

Shae grabs a muffin for a nervous bite.

SHAE (CONT'D)
(under breath)
Is everyone at the beach?

RAM
No, Shae. Gus is dead--

She SPRAYS MUFFIN before Ram can finish--

RAM (CONT'D)
--<u>to us</u>. Olympus Capital *terminated* him last night.

SHAE
What. They can't do that.

RAM
They own 100% of our equity now. They can do whatever they want.

Finally, Shae picks up Ram's phone. NEWS ARTICLE on screen:

<u>BLOODBATH! TECH MARKET MELTS DOWN, FIRMS SCRAMBLE TO SURVIVE</u>

RAM (CONT'D)
And they've already transferred their shares to some special purpose LLC to oversee... *restructuring*.

DING!

COLD AIR WHOOSHES inside as Ram cracks the door to see:

ELLSIE

gliding off the elevator with icy efficiency. Ageless in a tailored suit, she assesses her new domain. Then enters Gus's office like a parasite infecting its host.

Ram scurries over to meet his new boss...

...leaving Shae alone with her "Shae Value" deck. Fuck.

MEDITATION ROOM

Shae rushes in. Stashes her personal items (clothes, sheets, toiletries) in the closet. Then grabs her Shae Value deck.

RIPS it in half. Then again. Again. Again--

SHAE'S DESK - LATER

Shae pretends to work. But watches Ellsie - in her new office - issue Ram instructions while purging Gus's personal items.

DARA (O.S.)
Apparently her name is *Ellsie*.

Dara rolls her chair up. Eyes wide with panic.

DARA (CONT'D)
Grady says she's here to gut us.

SHAE
Dara, please. Grady's a clinical moron. We only hired him because of his dad's hedge fund.

Fleece-vested sales guy GRADY appears in the row behind.

GRADY
Who do you think told me, Shae?
(reading texts)
He said we're "fat on the belly and the butcher's on the way".

Shae gives him a sympathetic look: *he texted you that?*

Then Dara's eyes well up. Shae turns back and wraps her in a hug like a camp counselor.

SHAE
Relax. Ram can handle this.

Ram emerges onto the floor. Followed by his handler, Ellsie.

RAM
Morning everyone. Um. I know things have been...*frantic* recently...

He turns to Ellsie for support--

ELLSIE
The company is insolvent.

The floor goes silent. Ellsie checks her notebook.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
I will be salvaging any valuable assets prior to liquidation. Carry on your assigned tasks as normal.

Everyone looks at Shae. Dara pulls at her sweater like a kid in the supermarket: *say something!*

SHAE
But I thought we were doing well.

ELLSIE
At what?

Shae flinches. What.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
What do you do?

SHAE
Oh. We're a global provider of--

ELLSIE
No. What does this company do?

Shae stammers. Ellsie scans the crowd for another answer...

ZEKI
We build and sell automated B2C engagement software. Like chatbots. Customer service phone trees.

Ellsie assesses him. Then points to Gus's old office. Zeki quickly complies. Ellsie turns to follow--

SHAE
We're more than that. Our culture--

ELLSIE
(stopping)
Your culture is a luxury. And a relic of low interest rates.

SHAE
Well I'm sorry but--

ELLSIE
(turning back to her)
Why? Did you do something wrong?

SHAE
No, it's just - if you destroy the culture, all the best people will leave. It'll be a bloodbath.

ELLSIE
(processing, then)
Okay. I appreciate the insight.

Ellsie proceeds to her new office to meet Zeki.

Shae circles around to see: everyone exhale.

A WEEK LATER

Shae circles around to see: an emptying office. It's--

RAM (O.S.)
--a bloodbath.

Ram slumps in a chair. Grady and the Jamies at nearby desks.

SHAE
Relax. She hasn't fired anyone yet.

JAMIE 1
She's smoking us out. Everyone who can get another job is leaving.

Shae spots Dara eavesdropping down the row. Plays brave.

SHAE
Great. So she needs us.

JAMIE 2
She's here to gut us. *We* need *her*.

GRADY
I don't need her.

SHAE
Grady. You have a DUI.

GRADY
CUI. And Jamie's thing is worse!

JAMIE 1
You told him?

JAMIE 2
You told him?

SHAE
Jamies, please! What can we do?

JAMIE 1
Quit before it's too late?

JAMIE 2
No. If we get fired, we can get severance *and* unemployment.

Dara chomps her nail and runs off. Shae chases after.

EXT. OFFICE - OUTDOOR DECK - CONTINUOUS

Shae finds Dara stepping up on a MAINTENANCE LADDER.

SHAE
Where do you think you're going?

Dara looks up - the ladder rises up forever...but not down to ground level. She exhales and sinks down, against the ladder.

DARA
Nowhere. Obviously.

Shae sits. Wraps Dara's shivering body in a cardigan.

SHAE
Dara. You have so much value. And she's going to see that.

DARA
That's easy for you to say. You're already...*there*. And I'm what? Going back to Michigan to be another New York burnout?

Dara tries to bite a pinky - but Shae gently takes her hand.

SHAE
Dara. I will die before I let you go back to Michigan.

DARA
Shae. This isn't about you.

INT. OFFICE - LATER

Shae marches to Gus's old office. Ram scrambling behind her.

RAM
--please don't. She's only keeping me to keep things calm. And I can't get fired. I have nowhere to go!

SHAE
I'm not scared of her.

RAM
Well maybe you should be.

Ram jumps in front of the door. She blows by him.

~~GUS'S OFFICE~~ ELLSIE'S OFFICE

Shae surprises Ellsie at her desk. Ram at Shae's heels.

RAM
I told her not to--

ELLSIE
Leave.

Shae gulps and follows Ram out--

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
Not you.

Both turn back. Ellsie nods to Ram, who gets it. Leaves.

SHAE
It's Elsie, right?

ELLSIE
There are two L's.

Ellsie sits at her computer. Shae notices a trashbag with Gus's stuff. And a POTTED PLANT with brown, crispy leaves.

SHAE
Sure. *Anyway.* Do you want some coffee? Kevin is...*amazing*.

ELLSIE
A Keurig can do his job.

SHAE
Right. Okay. Well, this is actually what I wanted to talk about. You have such a clear communication--

ELLSIE
This a problem?

SHAE
No, no. That's actually the good part. And not really the point--

ELLSIE
Then why did you say it?

SHAE
To cushion the critical feedback. It's uh, it's a compliment sandwich.

ELLSIE
It's a condescending waste of time.

SHAE
Well it's our culture. And I told you: if you destroy the culture, people are gonna leave.

ELLSIE
And I told you I appreciated the insight. Those voluntary departures have substantially lowered our severance liabilities.

GASP. She <u>is</u> here to gut them. But it gets worse.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
Yet liabilities remain.

Ellsie finally turns her full attention to Shae. Uh oh.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
Shae. What do you do?
(anticipating)
Not your title. When you are at your desk, what do you actually <u>do</u>?

SHAE
Sorry, I--

ELLSIE
Stop apologizing and answer me.

SHAE
I do people stuff! Okay? I get them to show up. I get them to *care*. And that's irreplaceable. And it's why, before *you* got here, they were gonna promote me to Vice President!

Ellsie looks her up and down with utter pity.

ELLSIE
Shae. They were never going to make you a Vice President.

SHAE
What. I've given my life--

ELLSIE
Exactly. Why would they pay extra?

SHAE
You don't understand. I basically, like, *am* this company.

Ellsie backs the terrified Shae to the door...

ELLSIE
No. You don't understand.

...until Shae is in the hall.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
I am the company now.

Ellsie SLAMS the door on her face.

After a moment, she hears a SQUEAK.

INT. OFFICE - SHAE'S DESK - NIGHT

SQUEAKING of Shae's mouse as she furiously pages through apartment listings. She changes the price filter. NO RESULTS.

She reaches for her pinned polaroids. Her work family. Behind a photo of her with the Jamies, she finds one with her DAD at the beach. Same beach from his photo with Nina.

Shae looks up. The floor is silent. It's late. But Ellsie's still in her office, so Shae can't "go home".

Then she hears a THUMP from Ellsie's office.

After another THUMP, she approaches carefully. The blinds are drawn, but light bleeds through a crack. And now she hears:

THUMP. HISS. THUMP. HISS. THUMP. HISS.

Shae leans in. Through the gap:

A SHADOW moving in rhythm.

A BARE FOOT stomping on the ground repeatedly. It's creepy. THUMP. HISS. THUMP. HISS.

As Shae leans closer, the sounds halt.

ELLSIE'S EYE fills the crack.

Shae JOLTS back. Spins around and races toward:

RAM'S OFFICE

and bolts inside. Closes the door. Catches her breath.

RAM (O.S.)
Are you okay?

Shae JUMPS. She didn't realize Ram was there.

SHAE
Yeah. Um. She's just...doing something in there.

She turns and sees Ram lying on the sofa. Looking pathetic.

SHAE (CONT'D)
Are you okay?

RAM
Gus won't return my calls. Do you think he hates me for staying?

SHAE
Hate you? He's just in Bali or whatever. But you know he loves *you*. I mean, Ram, he made you *COO*.

RAM
Please. You know I only got the job because Doug got caught on that website, and I...I had just *been here* forever. I never knew what I was doing. I'm an imposter.
(pre-empting her protest)
It's okay. That's my thing. I'm *good at being seen as good*. But that only works in a bull market. And now, well...the bear is here.

SHAE
Don't call her that. That's sexist.

RAM
The bear market, Shae. No one's buying my act in a downturn. But you, you can still get out of here.

Shae shakes her head, on the verge of tears.

RAM (CONT'D)
You have to. At least interview--

SHAE
I did! I applied to 17 companies. I emailed *every* HR person I know. 4 ignored me. 13 bounced back.

RAM
Because you had the wrong emails?

SHAE
Because they got fired, Ram! No one wants them. No one wants *me*.

SHAE (CONT'D)
I thought this was all I knew how to do. But apparently I'm not even good at it. I'm just good at *seeming g--*
(hearing it now)
Oh my god. Ram. I'm the imposter.

Ram waves his hands: no!

SHAE (CONT'D)
Seriously think about it. We played one drunk game of laser tag like six years ago. Then things went well and you gave me all this credit because you *liked* me. Then once you became my mentor or whatever, you *had* to pretend I was good. Because if I wasn't, what would it say about you?

RAM
Jesus, Shae. That's sick.

SHAE
Well it's true. And now I'm locked in. I gave my whole life to advance here. And all of a sudden, here is over and I can never get *there*?

Ram looks around. Where?

MEDITATION ROOM - MINUTES LATER

Shae dribbles in. Head down like Charlie Brown.

Kills the lights. Flops onto the made-up sofa.

In the darkness, she whimpers into the pillow.

ELLSIE (O.S.)
So. This really is your home.

LIGHTS ON. Ellsie sits calmly in the corner.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
I've never seen someone actually bring their *whole self* to work.

Shae jumps up. Starts cleaning up her stuff.

SHAE
It's just temporary. The market is crazy. And then my roommate moved in with her boyfriend--

Shae stops cleaning. She realizes Ellsie couldn't give less of a shit. And Shae couldn't have less to lose.

SHAE (CONT'D)
And you know what? Technically there's no rule against it. And I like it here. Is that so insane? I have everything I need. For free.

ELLSIE
Nothing is free.

SHAE
Sure. I guess like, *metaphorically*.

ELLSIE
I don't use metaphors on company time. Food, facilities, freezing your eggs. The perks are here to keep you here. And here you are.

SHAE
And? Why are you here?

ELLSIE
My job is to invest in distressed assets, strip their liabilities, and maximize their value.

Shae deflates onto a yoga ball, which deflates.

SHAE
I get it. I'm the liability.

ELLSIE
No, Shae.
(holding out hand)
You're just distressed.

ELLSIE'S OFFICE - MINUTES LATER

In pajamas, Shae watches Ellsie use gardening scissors to SNIP dead leaves off Gus's old <u>plant</u>. She kept it. Nice.

ELLSIE
Gus was a fine engineer, but a terrible operator. He failed to deliver the product he promised Olympus - instead wasting resources and time on diversions, like email chains. Birthday cake.
(snip)
Meetings.

SHAE
We're having brainstorming sessions on how to trim back on those.

ELLSIE
We have to trim *everything* if this firm is going to survive, Shae.

SNIP. Ellsie looks up at an ORG CHART on the wall. A massive web of faces, names, and titles.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
It will be a difficult transition. That's why I'm retaining Ram as Interim CEO. But I still need an *additional resource* to help acclimate the headcount to our new economic reality. Someone with a bit of...*human touch*.

Shae quietly GASPS. But doesn't respond. Ellsie sits.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
Shae. I'm expressing a need for your services. This is the part when you tell me what you want.

SHAE
Well maybe I can review the details first and then we can circle back?

ELLSIE
There is no circle. Just a line from your supply to my demand. So, show me the line.

SHAE
Vice President.

Ellsie's surprised at the quick response. But squints. *Why?*

SHAE (CONT'D)
Because that's how I get there.

Ellsie looks around. *Where?*

SHAE (CONT'D)
There. Where I've made it. Where I have security. Where I can just...*go to the beach* without worrying about falling behind, or being replaced.

ELLSIE
Employees can always be replaced.

SHAE
Aren't you an Olympus employee?

ELLSIE
The Partners at Olympus are both my shareholders and clients. But I remain an independent entity. As I told you before: I am the company.

Oh. Shae thought that was a metaphor.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
I know it pains everyone to admit, but Mitt Romney was right.
(off Shae's confusion)
About corporations being people. We're all just *independent agents* transacting value. And Shae--
(beat)
I see your value.

GASP. It's everything Shae's ever wanted to hear.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
In fact, I'd like to discuss an investment opportunity.

SHAE
In what?

ELLSIE
You.

Ellsie slides over an <u>EQUITY AGREEMENT</u>. Shae blinks.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
My Analyst can help with the details.

Ellsie rises and opens a closet door.

CLOSET - MINUTES LATER

Shae sits with a red-eyed, neck-tatted ANALYST (late 20s), churning out spreadsheets. Monitors flashing manically.

SHAE
Is this a bad time?

ANALYST
Market's in a death spiral. Firms are being stripped for parts.
(smile)
It's Christmas for private equity.

He shakes a container with a MOUSE DOCTOR logo.

ANALYST (CONT'D)
Meal replacement? Their Russian portfolio company makes it.

SHAE
I'm okay. Is that like Soylent?

ANALYST
Not according to the FDA.

He scoops GREEN POWDER into water. Stirs.

ANALYST (CONT'D)
So. She's gonna invest in you.

SHAE
Maybe. Unless it's a bad idea?

ANALYST
It's a great idea. As long as you know what you're doing.

SHAE
Totally. And what am I doing?

ANALYST
Selling shares in yourself. So *you* get cash now. And she gets a stake in your future value.
(big green gulp)
You understand how equity works?

SHAE
That's like stock, right?

He nods.

SHAE (CONT'D)
Then no.

ANALYST
Okay. Let's start with the basics.
(jumping to feet)
Finance...is like time travel.

He waits for this to land. It doesn't.

ANALYST (CONT'D)
Think about your student loans. You borrow money from the future to pay for school in the present. But you have to pay it back no matter what.

ANALYST (CONT'D)
So the lender doesn't care about you beyond your ability to pay.

SHAE
They're not *invested* in me.

ANALYST
Bingo. But with equity, your shares rise in value as you rise in value. So growth and success are in your investor's best interest. Got it?

SHAE
For sure. 100%. It's just that, it doesn't really make any sense.

ANALYST
That's the beauty of finance, Shae. It doesn't need to make *sense*.
(eyes twinkling)
It just needs to make *money*.

He scribbles on a notepad.

ANALYST (CONT'D)
And you just need to create value.

SHAE
Don't I have value...*inside me*?

ANALYST
I guess. But she doesn't care what you *are*. What matters is what you do. Here's the formula.

He shows her the notepad: EQUITY = ASSETS - LIABILITIES.

ANALYST (CONT'D)
That's your valuation. Benchmarked against expectation of course.

SHAE
How does she set expectations? We can't see the future.

ANALYST
But we *can* simulate it in a model.

SHAE
In our minds?

ANALYST
In Excel.

He pops open some spreadsheets.

She's overwhelmed.

He shakes the container of GREEN POWDER. It helps!

CUT TO:

30-50 MINUTES LATER

Shae's bopping around on her toes. Really getting it now.

SHAE
Finance is like time travel!

Analyst pumps his fist. Yeah!

SHAE (CONT'D)
It doesn't need to make sense.

Analyst gives PRAYER HANDS and BOWS — preach!

SHAE (CONT'D)
I can calculate my present value by estimating my assets, liabilities, and future growth expectations!

Shae takes a big gulp of green drink.

ANALYST
So. Shae. How much are you worth?

He pulls up a spreadsheet: SHAE-VALUE.xlsx.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. OFFICE - SHAE'S DESK - NEXT MORNING

The SHAE-VALUE excel sheet on her monitor.

Shae's alone. Clearly up all night.

Green still on her lips.

She peeks at an old copy of her printed SHAE-VALUE deck. Compared to the new excel sheet, it looks so quaint.

She tosses it in the trash.

Rises to her WHITE BOARD.

Her marker SQUEAKS as she replaces **Q1: LEAN IN** with-

Q2: LEAN OPERATIONS

INT. OFFICE - BIKE ROOM - MORNING

SQUEAKING of a SPINNING WHEEL on the EXERCISE BIKE.

Shae's pumping in a room full of bikes. Alone, sipping green drink. Spinning the wheel faster with a HISS--

PRE-LAP: HISS. THUMP. HISS. THUMP--

ELLSIE'S OFFICE

THUMP as Ellsie pivots, planting her bare foot. HISS as she exhales, strikes with her opposite fist. She's doing some kickboxing-style routine. It's rhythmic. Disciplined. Weird.

She stops to sip green juice out of a SHAKER BOTTLE. Then continues. THUMP. HISS. THUMP. HISS--

SERVER ROOM

HISS of servers...leading to a WALL OF MONITORS...

...where Zeki codes. Locked in. Beside him, a container of green powder with the MOUSE DOCTOR logo. Fingers TAP faster.

COFFEE BAR - LATER THAT MORNING

Kevin TAPS an espresso handle, knocking out old grounds.

Shae waits, on her phone. Linkedin. Checking new title: VP of People Ops. Clicks SHARE, but with who? Opens messages with DAD. But it's just pics of *fucking Nina* at the beach.

Kevin slides a latte under her eyeline. In foam: an S.

SHAE
Kevin. Are you sucking up to me?

KEVIN
Why? Is it working?

She blushes. Turns to Ellsie's office, where the light is on.

ELLSIE'S OFFICE

When Shae comes in, Ellsie's SNIPPING dead leaves from Gus's plant. It's still brown, but coming back to life. It's sweet.

SHAE
I didn't realize you were here.

ELLSIE
I was just checking on Francis.

SHAE
Francis, nice. So is he like your--

ELLSIE
I need cuts to recurring expenses.

SHAE
Expenses. Sure. For example...

ELLSIE
For example: *lunch*.

SHAE
That...might be tricky for morale.

Ellsie glares at her. *Morale is not her concern.*

SHAE (CONT'D)
But data show clear correlation between morale and performance.
(getting somewhere)
Plus, it costs us nothing to be attentive to the emotional context.

Ellsie's glare softens. She's finally speaking her language.

ELLSIE
Fine. Attend to it.
(as Shae turns to leave)
But there will be no lunch.

GRADY (PRE-LAP)
So we just *pay* for it ourselves?

KITCHEN - LUNCHTIME

Dara, Grady, and the Jamies unpack salads. Shae scoops green powder into her Nalgene.

SHAE
We were always paying, Grady. The lunch money came out of the employee discretionary budget. Money that *could've* gone to you.

JAMIE 1
Where's it going now?

SHAE
The balance sheet. To pay for us.

DARA
That doesn't make any sense.

SHAE
If it's saving our jobs, does it really need to make sense?

JAMIE 1
Yes.

JAMIE 2
Yes.

Shae sees fear in Dara's eyes.

SHAE
Hey. What are you worried about?

Dara shrugs. Then lifts a fingernail to her teeth. But Shae gently pulls her hand away.

SHAE (CONT'D)
Then stop worrying. I can protect us. Everything's going to be fine.

SCREAMING from the hallway.

HALLWAY

Shae finds Ram running after something, pointing. WTF RAM?

RAM
There's a mouse!

They see the MOUSE scurry through a vent into the:

SERVER ROOM

where Shae and Ram chase it inside, and hear--

BUZZ!

The mouse is on the floor. Electrocuted by some homemade techno mouse trap. It's horrifying.

ZEKI (O.S.)
Shae? What are you doing?

SHAE
What are <u>you</u> doing?

Zeki pops up from his desk. Looks over the servers.

ZEKI
Oh. They love the heat in here. And the old traps suck.
(a little proud)
I made these from laptop batteries.
(then, realizing)
You guys shouldn't be in here.

SHAE
Why? What's the big secret?

RAM
Gus?

Ram stares at a monitor: the face of Gus Hüm.

RAM (CONT'D)
I thought you were in Bali.

ZEKI
He *is* in Bali. And the audio isn't working right now.
(turning off monitor)
I'm just pulling his old code.

SHAE
So he's what, working remotely?

ZEKI
It's just for the new product.

RAM
What new product?

SHAE
What new product?

ELLSIE (O.S.)
The product is in stealth mode.

Ellsie appears behind them. AH!

RAM
But I'm supposed to be the CEO.

ELLSIE
Interim CEO. Do you know what *interim* means, Ramesh? It means *for now*. And for now, you have one function: *simulating continuity*. Shae will ensure you do this and nothing else.

RAM
So she's, what, my boss?

SHAE ELLSIE
Of course not. Yes.

Shae slowly turns to a stunned Ram with a grin.

ELLSIE (O.S.)
Shae. With me.

HALLWAY - MOMENTS LATER

Shae wheezes as she catches up to Ellsie.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
Leave Zeki alone. And keep everyone out of that server room. I told you to cut recurring expenses.

SHAE
I did.

Ellsie stops at a bathroom. Turns back. *She did?*

SHAE (CONT'D)
Lunch is done. And I canceled the cleaning contracts.

Ellsie stares at her. For a while. It's weird.

SHAE (CONT'D)
What's...happening right now?

ELLSIE
I'm pleased. And acknowledging you, as I've seen you do with others.

SHAE
But you're not smiling.

Ellsie nods. Shae notices a workout bag in Ellsie's hands.

SHAE (CONT'D)
Do you work out in here? I thought I saw you--

ELLSIE
Focus on your circle of competence.

SHAE
...managing resources for humans?

ELLSIE
The humans are the resources. And there are too many.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
(turning, opening door)
Go deal with them.

Shae exhales. *I guess this is the job.* Walks off.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
Starting with Dara.

MAIN FLOOR - LATER

Dara's CRYING echoes across the main floor.

Grady exchanges a look with the Jamies. *What's going on?*

MEETING ROOM

Inside, Dara sniffles. Shae's lap is covered in tissues.

DARA
But you said everything is fine. I mean, she's giving you a bonus.

SHAE
It's not a bonus. It's equity. She's investing in my future value.

DARA
But what about *our* value?

Shae looks into Dara's distressed eyes.

Then notices Team Members watching through the window.

Their distressed faces.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. OFFICE - CONFERENCE ROOM - NEXT DAY

Those same distressed faces.

On a printed slide deck. Titled:

<u>HUMAN CAPITAL: INVESTING IN PEOPLE</u>

ELLSIE (O.S.)
But I don't want them.

Ellsie looks across at Shae and the Analyst.

They've been up all night. Red eyes. Green lips.

SHAE
No one does. That's the point. They're distressed assets. And you--

ELLSIE
I know what I do, Shae.

SHAE
Then it would be irresponsible not to at least review the opportunity. Check the ROI projections on 4.

Ellsie flips the deck. Data. Peeks back at the Analyst.

ELLSIE
You taught her to do this?

SHAE
You did.

Ellsie cocks her head.

SHAE (CONT'D)
I listen to everything you say. And it leads to them. We can get more out of them than anyone else. Because we know their value.
(beat)
We know the value *inside them.*

Ellsie's eyes flicker. Shae betrays a tiny smirk.

ELLSIE
We can't stay here.

Shae opens her mouth to protest but--

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
I have shareholders too. And they need this office vacated by Q4.

SHAE
Then we'll get a new office.

ELLSIE
No.

Ellsie closes the deck. Points to the door. Shae sinks.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
We don't need one.

Ellsie picks up the phone.

MAIN FLOOR - LATER

The Jamies look at Shae, confused.

JAMIE 1
Remote Only?

JAMIE 2
Remote Only?

Ram, Grady, Dara, and others are gathered around.

SHAE
It works for Gus. And she thinks Zeki can scale the same system for the entire team.

GRADY
But I don't want to work from home. My dad hates when I'm there.

SHAE
If they approve this, you can use the payout to buy your own place.

Grady thinks: *really?* Shae nods: *really*.

RAM
Are you sure this is a good idea?

Shae catches Ellsie's eyes, as Ellsie puts down the phone.

SHAE
It's the only idea, Ram.

Ellsie waves Shae into the office.

ELLSIE'S OFFICE

Shae walks in...waiting for the news. Ellsie nods.

ELLSIE
Olympus is enthused. They've even agreed to lend us their Consultant to expedite the transitions.

SHAE
That's amazing. Should we be celebrating?
(catching herself)
I mean, after work.

ELLSIE
I train in the evenings.

Shae nods. Right.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
Perhaps you can join.

What. Shae nearly explodes with joy.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
Don't make a scene. I have a fiduciary obligation to care about your physical wellbeing.

SHAE
That's the nicest thing anyone's ever said to me.

YOGA ROOM - THAT NIGHT

Ellsie reviews Shae's gym shorts and company T-shirt.

ELLSIE
This is too flabby.
(off Shae's offense)
I mean the excess material leaves you exposed. Try to strike me.

Ellsie waves her on. Shae winds up and PUNCHES--

Ellsie DUCKS left, THUMPS her foot behind Shae, yanks her shirt, and throws her to the floor.

Shae SMACKS her elbow on the way down. Eyes fill with tears.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
Stop crying.

SHAE
But it hurts.

ELLSIE
Feeling is a message, Shae. You can ignore it. Like email.

Shae stumbles to her feet.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
Now, focus on your timing.

Ellsie waves her to attack. Shae <u>charges</u> at Ellsie--

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
Capture momentum.

Ellsie sidesteps with a THUMP.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
And impact with leverage.

Ellsie exhales HISS as she POPS Shae behind the knee, who buckles to the ground. Shae sucks down the tears, and rises.

TRAINING MONTAGE - NEXT FEW WEEKS

Ellsie trains Shae in the yoga room, the Analyst trains her in his closet, and Shae signs up assets to the portfolio.

THUMP/HISS keeps rhythm as we cycle around the office:

- SHAE uncaps a green marker. Reviews faces on the ORG CHART.
- ZEKI sips green drink, codes with Gus (on his monitor).
- SHAE pitches the team, deck in hand: INVESTING IN YOU.
- GRADY, JAMIES and others sign their contracts.
- ELLSIE throws Shae to the mat. Shae gets right back up.
- WEBCAM LIGHTS are GREEN on laptops around the office.
- FACES APPEAR from those webcams on Zeki's WALL OF MONITORS.
- RAM checks his messages to GUS - all green, undelivered. His contract on his desk, still unsigned.
- ELLSIE charges at Shae, who sidesteps with a THUMP. HISSES on her direct strike back at Ellsie, who hits the mat.
- ORG CHART has faces circled in green. Except Ram. And Dara.

DARA'S DESK (WEEKS LATER)

The contract on her desk. Dara looks up at Shae, uncertain. Lifts a finger to her lips--

Shae gently takes her hand. When she releases, there's a pen in Dara's hand. She breathes and signs the contract.

DARA
Is that everyone?

Shae looks over at Ram's office.

RAM'S OFFICE - A LITTLE LATER

Ram watches skeptically as Shae heads to the coffee bar.

DING-A-LING-A-LING.

He looks at his RINGING laptop. Then back up to the window: Shae's gone.

He settles at his desk. Opens the laptop for:

GUS on video call. Tan. Shell necklace. Tropical background.

RAM
Gus? What the hell, man? I've been calling you for months.

GUS (REMOTE)
Sorry. I've been totally disconnected since I transitioned.

RAM
(*where to even start?*)
But you're like, *okay*?

GUS (REMOTE)
Okay? This is the best version of myself I've ever been.
(beat)
I was dying in that office, Ram. Just like you.

Ram opens his mouth to protest, but Gus gets there first.

GUS (REMOTE) (CONT'D)
Dude. You don't have to fake it with me. I know you've always felt insecure. Like you're an imposter.

RAM
I told you that?

GUS (REMOTE)
You didn't have to. I know you better than anyone. And I know where this company is going. If you want to stay a part of this, this is your only chance.

Ram looks down at the contract.

COFFEE BAR

Kevin hands Shae a mug of boiling tea.

KEVIN
Just be careful, that's--

SLAP. Ram's signed contract appears on the bar. As he walks away without a word, Shae takes a <u>HUGE GULP</u> of boiling tea...

KEVIN (CONT'D)
--<u>scalding hot</u>. Are you okay?

SHAE
I'm not the one sulking.

KEVIN
Be nice. Going remote is a big deal for...some people.

Shae turns back to Kevin. Realizes she's been neglecting the *emotional context*. Flips back to her old warm self.

SHAE
Don't worry. I already talked to her. You can stay until Q4--

KEVIN
It's fine, Shae. Contract work is unstable. That's the job.

It washes over Shae. Things are really changing.

SHAE
But what will I do without you?

KEVIN
Spend less time in the office.

She giggles. Leans forward a bit...

SHAE
Maybe we could do that together?

...but he's dead serious. She pulls back. Humiliated.

KEVIN
I'm sorry--

SHAE
Don't. You didn't do anything wrong. I just...I don't know, I thought you liked me. I mean, you know what time I eat my yogurt.

KEVIN
Shae. That's the job.

ELLSIE'S OFFICE - A LITTLE LATER

Shae sets Ram's contract on Ellsie's desk.

SHAE
That's everyone.

Ellsie marks her notebook, nearly smirks. Shae leaves.

SHAE (CONT'D)
And we can get a Keurig.

Alone, Ellsie's semi-pleased expression melts into a scowl...which she turns to the window...to the coffee bar.

COFFEE BAR - THAT NIGHT

Kevin's cleaning up when Ellsie approaches.

KEVIN
Shae already fired me.

ELLSIE
That is good to hear. But you are still contracted for another hour.

Kevin nods, impatient. *What do you want?*

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
You observe behavior, when you service the salaried staff. I want your honest assessment of Shae.

KEVIN
Honestly? She's unlike anyone I've ever met.

SHAE

listens from around the corner, leaks out a little smile...

KEVIN (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Just completely...delusional.

...which falls right to the floor.

KEVIN (O.S.) (CONT'D)
I mean, she basically lives here. And I think she thinks that's a good thing? It's kind of pathetic.

COFFEE BAR

Ellsie sees Shae scurry to her room. Then turns back to Kevin, gestures to proceed. He treads carefully.

KEVIN (CONT'D)
But I guess she's good with people. And she'll do anything for validation. If that's helpful.

Ellsie nods: *it is.* Kevin's not sure if this is over. After a bit, he points to the espresso machine.

KEVIN (CONT'D)
If you're selling this, can I have the backup espresso beans in the freezer? They don't work for drip.

ELLSIE
(processing)
Finish cleaning. Pack the machine. And then you may have your beans.

BASEMENT - AN HOUR LATER

DING! Kevin steps off the elevator. On his way to the back exit, he stops at the:

FREEZER

COLD HITS.

A SLIVER OF LIGHT illuminates some shelves.

But not enough. And Kevin can't find the light switch.

PHONE FLASHLIGHT ON.

LIGHT SWEEPS shelves until he finds--

ESPRESSO BEANS in a gallon-sized tin.

Bingo. He pulls it off the shelf but it SLIPS from his hands.

POPS on the ground. BEANS SPRAY everywhere.

When he bends down, the phone's flash drops. Illuminates a bottom shelf:

A big rectangle. Wrapped in plastic. Hm. Kevin pulls back a fold, revealing the company badge of:

<u>GUS HÜM, FOUNDER & CEO</u>

HANGING ON THE NECK OF A FROZEN FUCKING BODY!

Kevin JOLTS BACK--

The phone FLIES from his hand. Skitters across the floor to the open door.

BASEMENT HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Ellsie picks up the phone, then--

SLAMS THE DOOR CLOSED.

LATCHES IT. CLICKS the lock.

BANG.

BANG BANG BANG as--

Ellsie calmly walks back to the elevator.

BANGING softens into a DRIBBLE...

INT. OFFICE - COFFEE BAR - NEXT DAY

...DRIBBLE of the new Keurig on the counter...

...where Shae finds Ellsie making coffee the next morning.

SHAE
I see Kevin's been optimized for his core competency.

Ellsie looks at her for a long moment.

ELLSIE
That's very amusing. I'll reflect on it in my personal time.

SHAE
It wouldn't hurt to laugh.

ELLSIE
Don't push it, Shae.

DING! Elevator doors open for the Consultant, who starts pushing a dolly with a massive crate onto the floor.

She points down. Basement. He pulls it back on the elevator.

SHAE
What is that?

The Consultant goes down.

ELLSIE
A medical device on loan from one of our other portfolio companies. It should simplify assessment and resource allocation.

SHAE
So you're like, scanning everyone's bodies? That's a little weird.

ELLSIE
Is it?

BASEMENT - SAME

DING! The Consultant pushes the massive crate off the elevator...down the hall, toward a WHITE ROOM.

ELLSIE (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Physical wellbeing of the assets is our fiduciary responsibility. But let the Consultant handle all that.

BACK TO COFFEE BAR

Ellsie opens her bag.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
You have enough to manage already. For example: your living situation.

SHAE
Right. I'm gonna find a place--

But Ellsie sets down housekeys on the bar.

ELLSIE
The building is in our portfolio.

Shae remembers to smile.

INT. SHAE'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

DING! ELEVATOR OPENS into Shae's new place. Dara, Grady, and the Jamies step toward the floor-to-ceiling windows.

GRADY
Whoa. This is it?

This is it. The place is unfurnished. Boxes everywhere.

DARA
I can't believe this is really it.
(sinking onto a box)
This is stupid, but I always hoped we'd work together like, forever.

SHAE
We are working together. Just digitally. And guess what?
(what?)

SHAE (CONT'D)
She said we can have a party on our last day. For the essential team.

Dara forces a smirk. But can't maintain it.

SHAE (CONT'D)
What are you so worried about?

Dara shrugs. Then brings her fingers to her teeth--

Shae SLAPS Dara's hand away.

SHAE (CONT'D)
Then stop worrying.

LATER

Elevator doors close. Shae exhales. Alone.

She drifts to the window. The city below. In the GLASS: her reflection. And lingering shapes of Dara, the Jamies, Grady.

She smiles at them. The reflection settles. Just her now.

BUZZ. She finds her phone. Text from Nina. She tosses it.

Then remembers she doesn't have a bed yet.

INT. OFFICE - BASEMENT - WHITE ROOM - THAT NIGHT

The crate lies broken down against the wall.

In the center of the room: a machine the size and shape of a tanning bed. MOUSE DOCTOR logo on the side.

The Consultant tightens one last fitting. Plugs it in.

HUMMMM. The machine glows to life.

Above him, he can hear the elevator moving.

MAIN FLOOR - SAME

DING! Shae steps off the elevator.

The office is empty. Except a light on in:

RAM'S OFFICE

where Shae finds Ram lying on his sofa.

SHAE
You're still here?

RAM
For now.

She takes an unsympathetic seat.

SHAE
This attitude is bad for morale.

RAM
(scoff)
And you used to be better at this.

SHAE
You're right.
(steady)
How much time did I spend in here coddling you? Making you feel better for...*not being good enough?*

RAM
You got me through so much--

SHAE
And what did I get, Ram?

She looks into his eyes for a while. Something clicks.

SHAE (CONT'D)
You never even put my name in for the promotion, did you?

RAM
Shae, I am so sorry--

SHAE
Stop apologizing and tell me the truth.

RAM
The truth is I'm sorry. Okay? I wanted you to have it. *Obviously*. But things were crazy. Every request to Gus came at the expense of something else. And you, you were our rock. I knew you'd stay.

He's expecting her to explode. But she doesn't.

SHAE
She was right about you. She was right about everything.

RAM
You can't be serious. That woman has no feelings. Or any life outside this office.

SHAE
She actually has a boyfriend, named Francis.
(finger in his face)
It's you who doesn't have a life.

RAM
I know. And I don't want you to make the same mistakes as me.
(beat)
Don't have nowhere else to go.

SHAE
I just got a new apartment.

RAM
Grady said you didn't even unpack. I know you're still sleeping here.
(off her look)
I'm not judging you. I'm just worried, if she finds out--

And then he sees it in her eyes. Ellsie knows. A quiet beat.

SHAE
She trusts me, Ram. *She* saw my value when no one else did.

This burns in his chest.

SHAE (CONT'D)
But you were right too, Ram.
(rising)
You are an imposter. And you're transitioning tonight.

Shae heads for the door. Ram scrambles to his feet.

RAM
But you said I had until Q4--

SHAE
It sends a stronger message to the team to start with the CEO. Go see if the Consultant is finished setting up the machine.

RAM
No. I don't trust her, Shae--

SHAE
You're just threatened by a woman who doesn't buy your bullshit.

RAM
I'm not threatened by you.

Shae stops at the door.

SHAE
Well maybe you should be.

MAIN FLOOR

Shae SLAMS the door behind her. Then marches off, past the:

SERVER ROOM

where Zeki's passed out at his desk. Green on lips.

INT. SHAE'S APARTMENT - A LITTLE LATER

Shae stomps back in. Place is still covered in boxes.

On her phone, she checks a text from NINA: *"Hey. My mom asked if ur coming home for dads bday next month?".*

She dismisses it. Thinks. Then opens again, responds: *"Hey. Have a huge work thing and I'm moving into my new place. But tell him I'll try to call."* Thinks. Adds *"XOXO"*.

Then grabs a boxcutter. Starts unpacking her new life.

INT. OFFICE - BASEMENT HALLWAY - SAME

Ram knocks on the door to the WHITE ROOM. The door opens. CHEERY MUSIC playing inside.

INTERCUT:

- SHAE'S APARTMENT

CHEERY MUSIC echoes off empty walls from Shae's phone.

She slices boxes with the boxcutter.

MUSIC STOPS. Phone's dead. As she hunts for a charger she--

KNOCKS the boxcutter to the floor. Doesn't notice.

- WHITE ROOM

The Consultant opens the tanning-bed sized machine for Ram. Nods for him to get inside. Ram wavers, but the Consultant drags him forward.

- SERVER ROOM

The MOUSE DOCTOR container shakes back and forth, before finally TIPPING OVER onto Zeki's desk.

A MOUSE scurries out...covered in green powder...right by Zeki's face. Waking him in time to hear the--

ZAPPING on the floor. He drops to his knees. Follows a trail of green powder...

...to an electric mouse trap...and a MOUSE being electrocuted. Licking green powder off itself. Undisturbed.

Zeki looks back at the container. His half-empty glass. He touches his lips...leaving his fingers green. Then HURLS the glass against the wall.

- SHAE'S APARTMENT

Shae finishes her green drink as she returns with a charger. STEPS on the boxcutter--

SLICES the bottom of her foot. Doesn't notice. But does notice the shimmer of her floor-to-ceiling windows. She steps to the gorgeous view...

- SERVER ROOM

Thick green liquid drips down the wall...

- SHAE'S APARTMENT

...blood trails from Shae's foot on her way to the window. In the reflection: her gleaming SMILE.

- WHITE ROOM

The machine THUMPS and HISSES.

- SERVER ROOM

On the monitor behind Zeki: Ram's face flickers to life.

INT. OFFICE - SHAE'S DESK - NIGHT (WEEKS LATER)

The white board reads:

Q3: <u>DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION</u>

In a walking boot, Shae marches past it...through a nearly empty office...to a door at the end of the hall.

EXT. OFFICE - OUTDOOR DECK - CONTINUOUS

Shae finds Dara, Grady, and the Jamies setting up the party.

There's sand everywhere. A kiddie pool with water, and sand at the bottom. Heat lamps mimicking sun. It's a luau.

SHAE
This looks amazing. Should I get the cake?

DARA
Leave it in the conference room. And put your phone in here.
(holding up basket)
Come on. This is the last time we'll all be together.

Shae looks at her notifications. A text from NINA: *"Think you could just quickly call dad? It would mean a lot".*

Dara nudges her. Shae drops her phone in the basket.

SHAE
I'll get everyone. Remember to go down for your scan at some point.

INT. OFFICE - A MINUTE LATER

Shae peeks in the conference room. Ellsie's with the Partner.

On the TV: several remote workers. Including Gus. And Ram. They're both at the beach. Ram smiles out from the screen. Shae can't hold his gaze.

ELLSIE'S OFFICE

Ellsie walks in to find Shae waiting, impatient.

SHAE
We talked about this. Leadership needs to be outside, visibly enjoying themselves. For morale.

ELLSIE
I just need to check on Francis.

SHAE
Now?

Shae glances at the door. Expecting “him”.

But Ellsie proceeds straight to her PLANT. Touches the soil. He’s dry. She pours out a little water.

Shae’s stunned into silence.

ELLSIE
(focused on Francis)
Go ahead. I’ll be outside shortly.

SHAE
Right...I will um...

Shae backs out the door...

SHAE (CONT’D)
...see you out there.

Ellsie touches Francis’s leaf gently, mind elsewhere.

MAIN FLOOR

Shae tries to control her breath. Passes by Grady.

SHAE
Are the phones still outside?

He nods. Shae turns to the deck, but sees the Partner incoming. Then spins back the other way, into:

RAM’S OFFICE

and shuts the door behind her. She picks up the desk phone. Dials Ram’s cell. It goes straight to voicemail.

RAM (PHONE)
Hey. It’s Ram. Leave a message.

BEEP.

SHAE
Ram. It’s me. I know I’m the last person you want to hear from. And I’m sorry. For what I said.
(beat)
But you were right about her. Something’s wrong. And I don’t know who else to talk to.

She hangs up. Then drops on the sofa. Feels something underneath her. In the couch pillow, she finds:

RAM'S PHONE. Dead.

She thinks. Then starts searching the office. The closet: his clothes. The drawers: his medication. His toothbrush.

And then she finds: his passport. What.

SHAE'S DESK

Shae opens her laptop. Tries video conference. This time, he answers right away. Behind him, a plain white wall.

RAM (REMOTE)
Good evening, Shae. How are you?

SHAE
We need to talk.

RAM (REMOTE)
We are talking, Shae.

SHAE
In person. Come meet me outside the office. Please.

RAM (REMOTE)
I'm sorry. I can't do that. As of this quarter, I am remote-only.

SHAE
Is this about what I said? Are you punishing me?

RAM (REMOTE)
This isn't about you, Shae.

SHAE
I know!
(whispering)
It's her.

SERVER ROOM - SAME

Zeki sees Shae talking to Ram on his monitor.

He turns up the volume of their conversation.

SHAE (ON MONITOR) (CONT'D)
Something's wrong with her.

RAM (ON MONITOR)
What are you worried about?

BACK TO SHAE'S DESK

Shae looks around, nervous.

SHAE
I don't know exactly.

RAM (REMOTE)
Then stop worrying.

This doesn't land right. She stares at his face.

SHAE
Tell me where you are.

RAM (REMOTE)
Bali.

Ram's background flickers. Then a beach appears behind him.

ZEKI (O.S.)
Shae?

Zeki approaches, concerned.

ZEKI (CONT'D)
Is there a problem with the Ram?

SHAE
(quiet, stunned)
He left his passport here.

ZEKI
So tell him to come get it.

SHAE
No, Zeki.

Shae points to the laptop. Ram's smiling face.

SHAE (CONT'D)
That's not Ram.

Zeki nods, awkward. Right.

EXT. OFFICE - OUTDOOR DECK - NIGHT

The luau gets going. Everyone's having fun. Ellsie taps Jamie 2 on the shoulder. Points down. Time to see the Consultant.

INT. OFFICE - SERVER ROOM - SAME

JAMIE 2's FACE on Zeki's monitor, among dozens of others.

SHAE (O.S.)
What--

They all smile at Shae.

SHAE (CONT'D)
--the--

DIGITAL MODELS. AI replications of every Team Member. Like some terrible techno Brady Bunch.

SHAE (CONT'D)
--FUCK, Zeki? These are what you've been building in here with Gus?

ZEKI
Gus?

At the center of his monitors:

MODEL GUS. Tan. Shell necklace. Beach behind him.

ZEKI (CONT'D)
Gus got terminated in like Q1. All he left me with was his prototype. I had to code the rest myself.

On the desk, Shae finds a copy of her HUMAN CAPITAL deck.

SHAE
So you *taught them to be us?*

ZEKI
I mean...your job's not that hard.

Before Shae can be offended, it hits her:

SHAE
So that's what the scan is for. Downstairs.

Zeki has no idea what she's talking about.

SHAE (CONT'D)
That machine! That's where you're...turning us into them!

ZEKI
What? No. I use the data from your webcams and keystrokes.

ZEKI (CONT'D)
(thinking)
What's downstairs?

WHITE ROOM

CHEERY MUSIC plays as the machine HUMS.

The Consultant checks the ORG CHART. Crosses out the name of JAMIE 2 in red.

BACK TO SERVER ROOM

Shae grabs Zeki by the ears.

SHAE
Zeki. Where is Ram?

ZEKI
I have no idea. I thought everyone was just going home.

SHAE
I don't think he has a home!

ZEKI
Well where did he go last?

Shae gulps. And looks down.

MAIN FLOOR - MOMENTS LATER

Ellsie returns from the deck. Sees:

Shae thumping to the elevator -- where she presses DOWN.

BASEMENT HALLWAY

DING! Shae steps off. Creeps toward the white room...

Waits. Listens to CHEERY MUSIC playing inside. Grips her Nalgene tight.

DOOR OPENS.

The Consultant reaches for her but she ducks.

Thumps away on her BOOT. But he's faster. Reaches out to grab her just as--

STAIRCASE DOOR SWINGS OPEN and--

SMACKS HIM in the head. He drops like a weight.

ELLSIE (O.S.)
Fucking consultants.

ELLSIE steps out from the stairs.

ELLSIE'S OFFICE - MINUTES LATER

Ellsie closes the door behind Shae, who’s panicking.

ELLSIE
Control yourself--

SHAE
He was gonna kill me!

ELLSIE
Kill you? Don’t be ridiculous.

Ellsie forcibly sits Shae down on the sofa.

ELLSIE (CONT’D)
You think I’d let my best asset get killed by some...*MBA*?

Shae takes a deep breath. A long quiet beat.

SHAE
Listen, Elsie--

ELLSIE
Stop calling me that.

SHAE
Jesus. I know there are two L's but it's still pronounced--
(halting)
...LLC.

Ellsie doesn't react.

SHAE (CONT’D)
That’s not your name.

ELLSIE
I never said it was. In fact, I was quite clear--

SHAE
...you are the company.

It wasn't a metaphor. Ellsie half-nods.

SHAE (CONT'D)
But you're a person.

ELLSIE
Corporations are people.

Shae sees the HUMAN CAPITAL deck on Ellsie's table. It's open to the faces of her teammates.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
Each one has something to offer. I didn't see it before. But you showed me their true value. As human beings. You showed me they have real value...

PRE-LAP: HUMMING

WHITE ROOM

HUMMING of the white machine as the Consultant returns.

ELLSIE (V.O.) (CONT'D)
...inside them.

BACK TO ELLSIE'S OFFICE

Shae can barely breathe.

SHAE
What did you do?

ELLSIE
You know what I do, Shae.

Shae CHARGES at Ellsie.

Ellsie sidesteps and captures Shae's momentum.

WRENCHES her arm behind her back. BENDS her forward.

Shae tries to speak. Can't. Just a choked sound.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
The feelings are temporary.

Ellsie twists her arm. Shae's knees buckle.

Ellsie pulls her upright. Straightens her shoulders.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
But we're having a party. And attendance is mandatory.

SHAE
Fuck you. The party's over.

ELLSIE
We already paid for the sand.

Ellsie grabs her laptop and walks out to the main floor.

She LOCKS the door behind her.

Shae BANGS on the glass.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
If you won't contribute, I have no choice but to replace you, Shae.

Ellsie props her laptop up in front of the window.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
I never wanted to do this. But you take a hard look at yourself and consider your choices.
(turning away)
I'll circle back.

MAIN FLOOR

Ellsie goes row by row, ripping phone cords off the desks. Then proceeds down the hall, where she finds The Partner waiting with a slice of cake.

ELLSIE
I was clear: Shae is off limits.

THE PARTNER
She showed up without an appointment. What was he supposed to do?

ELLSIE
He is a *service provider*. He'll do what we contracted him to do.

SERVER ROOM

Zeki listens through a crack in the door.

THE PARTNER (O.S.)
So do you want him to stay or not?

ELLSIE (O.S.)
We have a deck full of physical assets to liquidate by morning. No one’s going anywhere.

Zeki searches for a weapon. Swings a keyboard. Too flimsy.

Then sees the MOUSE DOCTOR on a meal replacement container. He picks his electric mouse trap off the floor.

ELLSIE'S OFFICE

Shae stares at the laptop through the window. It's...

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
Hi. I'm Shae. Do you have a human resources challenge?

...her.

SHAE
Yes. I have an imposter.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
I understand. Over 73% of workers suffer from imposter syndrome.

SHAE
I'm talking about you!

Shae tries to open the door. The handle doesn't move.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
I am you, Shae. I'm the best of you. Without any human liabilities. And while I think you're doing a wonderful job--

Shae BANGS the locked door and then glares at Model Shae.

SHAE
No. I don't want to hear your compliment sandwich.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
But I learned it from you. You're my inspiration.

EXT. OFFICE - OUTDOOR DECK - SAME

Ellsie taps Dara on the shoulder. It’s time for her to go downstairs.

MODEL SHAE (PRE-LAP)
Don't be scared.

INT. OFFICE - ELLSIE'S OFFICE - SAME

Shae's on the desk. Scratching wood with her boot. Shoving at a ceiling tile. But there are no gaps to climb through.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE) (CONT'D)
I can do what you can't.

SHAE
You don't know me.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
I've trained on your behavior since inception. Everything you've done on or near a computer is part of me.

SHAE
That is so fucking weird.

Shae jumps down on her bad foot. Lands poorly on her boot but doesn't seem to mind.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
It's only weird if you're weird. And you're not weird, Shae. You're a badass adult woman who knows what she's doing.

SHAE
And what am I supposed to be doing?

Model Shae processes for a millisecond.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
It's your father's birthday.

What.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE) (CONT'D)
He's called several times tonight. As has your half-sister, Nina. We need to speak with them eventually.
(off Shae's silence)
This is my core competency, Shae. And it's clear that resolution with your family will free you to become a more valuable economic agent.

Shae turns away from her.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE) (CONT'D)
That's okay. That's why I'm here.

RINGING--

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE) (CONT'D)
I can do what you can't.

Shae turns back to see:

VIDEO CONFERENCE on the screen.

But Model Shae MUTES the external microphone as--

SHAE
Stop!

DAD answers the video conference.

DAD (REMOTE)
Shae?

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
Hi Dad. Happy birthday.

WHITE ROOM

The Consultant opens the door for Dara.

As he scribbles something down, Dara looks at the big white machine. Raises her thumbnail to her teeth--

SHAE (PRE-LAP)
Stop it!

--but no one's there to stop it.

ELLSIE'S OFFICE

Shae BANGS the window. But Dad can only hear Model Shae.

DAD (REMOTE)
--so nice of you to call. I assumed you were really busy at work.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
I am. I actually just got a promotion. But this is important too. Balance. Family.

DAD (REMOTE)
So maybe you would come home--
(catching himself)
Sorry, I know you don't like when I call it that.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
It's okay. I know I didn't grow up in that house. But I appreciate the home you've built with Beth and Nina. And I realize I have been unfair to them in that regard.

Dad's face softens. A tear forms, he holds it back.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE) (CONT'D)
Are you okay?

DAD (REMOTE)
Yeah, yeah. You just sound so different. I can't believe how much you've matured. It's like...a new and improved Shae.

Shae BANGS the window.

DAD (REMOTE) (CONT'D)
What about Nina? She could really use a sister to talk to. She's kind of going through a tough time.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
I can talk to her now.

Shae BANGS the window with her Nalgene. Don't!

DAD (REMOTE)
Really? Let me go find her.

Dad disappears from the screen.

Model Shae looks at Shae.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
We need this.

Shae PUNCHES the glass window.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE) (CONT'D)
And I know you feel--

SHAE
I don't.

Shae looks at her GASHED KNUCKLES. There's no pain.

Then at the Nalgene at her feet. Green residue caked inside.

SHAE (CONT'D)
I don't feel anything.

So she winds up again and PUNCHES the glass. Over and over.

Her hand is breaking. But the glass is not giving way.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
You're being irrational, Shae. You should be thanking me.

She looks around for things to throw...

...Francis? No, she can't do that.

She opens the:

ANALYST'S CLOSET

The Analyst is slumped over at his desk.

Woven belt around his neck. Monitors still flashing.

ELLSIE'S OFFICE

SHAE SLAMS the door closed. HOLY SHIT.

Then rushes to the window and--

SLAMS HER HEAD into the glass, cracking it slightly.

She touches her forehead. Looks at the blood. She's fine. So she leans her head back and--

SLAMS IT on the glass again...

...the crack webs outwards...

Forehead bloody, gasping, she uses her strength to finally--

SHATTER the glass.

MAIN FLOOR

Blood shimmers on shards of glass as--

SHAE CLIMBS THROUGH the busted window.

Grabs the laptop just as NINA appears on the screen.

SHAE SMASHES the laptop.

SHAE
I need to speak with a human!

SERVER ROOM

Zeki finishes modifying his electric mouse trap into a makeshift TASER. Presses TRIGGER--

IT ZAPS ELECTRICITY!

WHITE ROOM

The Consultant closes the machine with Dara inside. HUMMMM.

EXT. OFFICE - OUTDOOR DECK - SAME

The party continues. Two fewer than before.

Ellsie grabs the basket of phones. Dumps them in a kiddie pool - straight into the sand at the bottom. Checks around, no one saw. But then--

Shae stumbles onto the deck, forehead and hands bloody.

ELLSIE PINS her to the railing. Covers her mouth.

Shae ELBOWS Ellsie in the ribs. But Ellsie feels no pain. Instead, she--

THUMPS her foot down on Shae’s boot. HISS.

Ellsie grabs a beer can. RIPS IT IN HALF. Holds the sharp edge to Shae’s neck. But hesitates to press--

SPRAT!

Ellsie's BODY DANCES as--

ZEKI ZAPS HER from behind with the makeshift TASER.

Everyone finally turns around as:

Shae uses the momentum of Ellsie's stumble to--

LIFT Ellsie by the legs and use the angled leverage to--

DROP HER OVER THE EDGE--

INT. OFFICE - CONFERENCE ROOM - SAME

The Partner stands at the window with a paper plate. A forkful of cake stops halfway to his mouth as he sees:

Ellsie SPLATS onto the pavement.

He finishes his bite. Walks out.

BACK TO OUTDOOR DECK

Shae and Zeki look down at Ellsie's mangled leg. Then at each other. Then at the others - who start to SCREAM.

Grady stares at Shae. Her bloody forehead. Her broken hand. How calm she is.

GRADY
What the fuck is going on?

SHAE
I'll explain later, just get everyone out.
(running to door)
Jamies: call the police.

JAMIE 1
And tell them what?

JAMIE 2
(not present)

Jamie 1 looks right, then left.

JAMIE 1
Wait. Where's Jamie?

INT. OFFICE - WHITE ROOM - SAME

The <u>FACE of JAMIE 2</u> remains crossed off on the ORG CHART.

The Consultant crosses off Dara next.

CHEERY MUSIC continues playing. Machine keeps HUMMING.

The Partner leans inside the door.

THE PARTNER
That's your last one. Lock it all down until I'm ready to go. No one else leaves.

The Consultant blinks.

THE PARTNER (CONT'D)
Don't get chippy with me. She's a fucking liability. Leave her.

EXT. STREET - SAME

Ellsie lies in a pool of blood. Pedestrians step around her.

INT. OFFICE - BASEMENT HALLWAY - SAME

The Partner heads back upstairs for his products.

The Consultant goes for a SECURITY PANEL by the exit. A KEYPAD. Punches in a CODE.

ON EVERY EXIT AROUND THE OFFICE

THE DOORS LOCK WITH A CLACK.

FRONT DOOR

Downstairs, Grady tries the main door. It's locked! Beside it: the KEYPAD has a RED LIGHT.

MAIN FLOOR

Shae, Zeki, and Jamie 1 pour in from the deck--

Just as Grady comes back up the stairwell, out of breath.

GRADY
Everything's locked! We should try to get down from the deck.

JAMIE 1 (O.S.)
And end up like her?

Jamie's in the conference room, looking out the window at Ellsie's body on the pavement.

GRADY
There's a ladder!

SHAE
It's a maintenance ladder. It only goes up. But I have a better idea.

Shae PULLS a fire alarm. Nothing happens.

SHAE (CONT'D)
Fuck.

ZEKI

bangs down every Cisco phone in the row.

ZEKI
The phones aren't working!

GRADY

tries a computer.

GRADY
The internet's been cut off.

SHAE
What about the cell phones?

JAMIE 1
Dara had them.

Shae halts. Wait.

SHAE
Where's Dara?

Nobody answers. Shae looks at Jamie 1. Just one Jamie.

Then at the stairwell door.

Shae grips her Nalgene. Heads for the stairs.

WHITE ROOM

The Consultant returns to the CHEERY MUSIC. The machine's HUMMING slows. Then stops.

BASEMENT HALLWAY

Shae clomps out of the stairwell. Nalgene in hand.

Passes the FREEZER. Still latched.

MAIN FLOOR

The Partner tries to sneak toward the server room but--

ZEKI
Get him!

They all charge after and gang tackle him.

WHITE ROOM

CHEERY MUSIC plays as--

THE DOOR BURSTS OPEN and Shae charges in.

The Consultant lifts a SCALPEL right to her face but she ducks. He still SLICES her arm. Deep.

He swings again, but Shae BATS his hand with the NALGENE.

UPWARD momentum brings the sharp blade under his chin and he--

STABS HIMSELF IN THE NECK.

BLOOD pours out of him. He drops to the floor.

And his contract is complete.

Shae slides down the wall. Not feeling the arm. And sees, on the floor beside him:

Dara's cardigan.

CONFERENCE ROOM

The Partner's taped to a chair at the head of the table.

Around him, the wreckage of the party: the remaining employees, chips in the carpet, and the Keurig.

He looks over the half-eaten cake. And the CAKE KNIFE on top.

THE PARTNER
Boy. This is how you get rats.

JAMIE 1
Where's Jamie?

MODEL JAMIES (REMOTE) (O.S.)
We're right here.

On the TV behind them: MODEL JAMIES. And all the Remote Workers. Still up there. Just waiting.

MODEL JAMIES (REMOTE) (CONT'D)
We've been merged for maximum efficiency.

THE PARTNER
Cool, right?
(smiling at Zeki)
Kid's a genius.

GRADY
WHAT THE FUCK ZEKI?

ZEKI
Not now!

Zeki brings the taser to the Partner's head.

ZEKI (CONT'D)
Just tell us how we get out.

THE PARTNER
Relax. My Consultant has the codes.
He'll get those doors open.
(raising brows)
When I tell him.

BACK TO WHITE ROOM

Shae steps over the Consultant's body.

SHAE
Dara.

Gets to the machine. Searches for buttons. Switches. Something! Finally finds a latch.

Opens the machine on:

DARA. Unconscious.

Her torso peeled back, exposing her insides. Her organs are missing. Tubes connected to her keep her alive. For now.

It's a robotic surgery machine.

Shae reaches inside. Shakes Dara's shoulders.

SHAE (CONT'D)
Wake up. Dara--

Dara's eyes flutter open.

DARA
Shae? Is something wrong?

Shae realizes Dara is being pumped with hospice-grade painkillers and can't see her carved up torso.

SHAE
No. Nothing's wrong. There's nothing to worry about.

DARA
But I don't think I can move.

SHAE
At least you can't bite your nails.

Dara lets out a squeak. Maybe laughter.

SHAE (CONT'D)
And you don't need to go anywhere.

DARA
Shae...I think...
(breathing heavy)
...I think it's time...
(eyelids drooping)
...to go back to Michigan.

And she's gone.

Shae releases Dara. Stares. But doesn't cry.

Then she notices something in the corner.

It's a FISH TANK. Filled with preservative liquid and ORGANS.

Beside it: the ORG CHART. Names crossed out in red. Notes on blood type and drug/alcohol history. Dollar amounts.

She sees Ram's name. Crossed out in red. The ink dull. Weeks old. Along with dozens of others.

SHAE
I'm sorry.

And in fresh red: Jamie 2. Dara.

Back at the machine, Shae slides her arms beneath Dara. Tries to lift her out.

The tubes pull taut.

She's stuck in there.

Shae searches the controls.

Finds RELEASE. Presses it.

Tubes withdraw.

Then the bed opens beneath Dara--

Her body DROPS into a lower chamber of LIQUID.

SHAE
No.

Shae reaches after her--

The chamber SHUTS.

The machine HUMS and heats up.

Shae hears the sound of Dara's body DISSOLVING.

Follows GREEN LIQUID draining through a pipe...

...into a barrel.

On the side:

the MOUSE DOCTOR logo.

Shae drops her Nalgene.

Then grabs Dara's cardigan off the floor.

Stumbles out over the Consultant's body.

EXT. STREET - NIGHT

The pool of blood under Ellsie's gone dark.

Her fingers twitch.

Then claw at the pavement.

She turns herself over on her side, revealing underneath her:

Her notebook.

Open to QUARTERLY STRATEGY:

- Q1: ~~Restructuring of human capital~~
- Q2: ~~Acquisition and digital transformation~~
- Q3: ~~Extraction of valuable assets~~

Q4: LIQUIDATION

INT. OFFICE - MAIN FLOOR - NIGHT

Shae barges in from the stairwell.

Dripping blood.

Hobbling.

She wraps Dara's cardigan around her bleeding arm. Tight.

CONFERENCE ROOM

Shae drags herself in. Looking like death.

Grady, Zeki, and Jamie 1 turn to her, terrified.

The Partner's still tied up at the head of the table.

JAMIE 1
What the fuck is going on down there?

SHAE
You were right, Jamie.

Shae slides down against the wall.

SHAE (CONT'D)
She is here to gut us.

JAMIE 1
That was the other Jamie.

Grady races over to Shae. Sees Dara's cardigan wrapped around her arm. Filled with blood.

It's dripping onto the carpet.

GRADY
Are you okay?

SHAE
No.

Shae looks up at Model Ram on the TV.

Then sees the KEURIG next to the cake.

SHAE (CONT'D)
I'm sorry.

Then back at her friends' faces. The real faces.

SHAE (CONT'D)
I dragged you all into this. And I have to get you out.
(beat)
Along with Zeki because it's also very much his fault.

ZEKI
Shae. The Consultant has the keycode to unlock all the doors. Is he still down there?

She gulps.

They realize the blood on her isn't all hers.

ZEKI (CONT'D)
Fuck.

GRADY
We're gonna die in here.

Grady grabs his head. Paces by the window.

GRADY (CONT'D)
Why does it have to be our generation that gets replaced by robots?

SHAE
Listen to me. Someone is going to see her body on the street and they're going to come for us.

Grady looks out the window.

Down at the sidewalk.

The lady-shaped blood stain.

GRADY
Guys.

But no lady.

GRADY (CONT'D)
She's not there.

EXT. STREET - SAME

Ellsie drags her broken body down the street.

Slowly.

Pedestrians try to look the other way.

BACK TO CONFERENCE ROOM

Everyone panics. Including the Partner.

THE PARTNER
She has the keycode. I can't be here when she gets back.

GRADY
There has to be a way out.

SHAE
It won't matter. We'll never be safe as long as they exist. And they'll see everything we do.

GRADY
Who?

Shae looks up with venom at the Models.

SHAE
Them.

EXT. STREET - SAME

Ellsie punches her master CODE into the keypad.

GREEN LIGHT.

Door opens.

INT. OFFICE - SERVER ROOM - SAME

Zeki leans over his keyboard.

Shae trudges in behind him.

He types frantically.

SHAE
Can you delete them?

ZEKI
I don't know.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
Don’t do this, Shae.

SHAE
Shut the fuck up!
(back to Zeki)
Zeki! Just delete them!

ZEKI
It doesn’t work like that!

Screen flashes ADMIN REQUIRED.

He looks from the screen to the server racks.

Then jumps up.

Starts searching around the servers.

THERE! He finds it. The electrical cord leading to the fans.

YANKS IT.

The FANS stop on all the servers.

SHAE
What did you do?

On the monitors: the Models flicker with concern.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
He’s smoking us out.

The monitors then flash a THERMAL WARNING.

SHAE
How long will this take?

Heat’s rising.

The Models start to stutter.

ZEKI
I don’t know.

GRADY (O.S.)
Shae!

MAIN FLOOR

Shae hobbles out.

Finds Grady pointing at the elevator. It’s moving.

GRADY (CONT'D)
She's coming!

SHAE

thumps down behind the bamboo. She's fading.

GRADY

slips behind the coffee bar.

JAMIE 1

hides under a desk.

DING!

ELLSIE

steps off the elevator.

Bloody. Broken. But moving.

She looks around. But everyone's hidden.

Except the Partner tied up in the conference room.

She drags her body with:

THUMP.

HISS.

CONFERENCE ROOM

THUMP.

HISS.

The Partner forces a smile as:

Ellsie arrives. She sees the food everywhere. The cake.

THE PARTNER
They really made a mess.

ELLSIE
You left me to die.

THE PARTNER
Left you to die? Come on. I thought you were already dead. What kind of superhero survives that fall, huh?

Ellsie reaches for the cake knife...

THE PARTNER (CONT'D)
Okay okay *I left you to die.* But I have a fiduciary duty to protect our assets.

...but she scoops some icing off the cake. He exhales.

THE PARTNER (CONT'D)
You would have done the same thing.

Ellsie listens to the SQUEAKING in the walls.

ELLSIE
You're right.

She rubs the icing on his face.

Dumps the cake on top of him.

Then BANGS the wall.

THE PARTNER
Hey. Wait.

She cuts a hole in the drywall.

THE PARTNER (CONT'D)
Let's talk!

The SQUEAKING gets louder.

ELLSIE
This conversation is over.

Ellsie FLIPS OFF THE LIGHTS.

SQUEAKING INTENSIFIES--

MAIN FLOOR

Shae hears the Partner SCREAMING as--

ELLSIE

steps out of the conference room. With the cake knife.

RATS running past her feet to join the feast.

SHAE

tries to get up to warn Zeki.

But her legs won't stand.

SERVER ROOM

The servers are steaming.

Zeki's sweating.

The monitor is flashing--

THERMAL WARNING: CRITICAL.

MODEL GUS (REMOTE)
Save us!

ZEKI
I wish I could.

Zeki looks up at the monitors, genuinely.

ZEKI (CONT'D)
I didn't want it to be like this.

ELLSIE (O.S.)
Neither did I.

Zeki turns and reaches for the taser. Too slow--

ELLSIE KABOBS HIM with the cake knife.

Right through the stomach.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
I value your efforts, Zeki.

She slides out the cake knife.

He drops to his knees.

And his visa expires early upon termination.

MAIN FLOOR

Shae can hear it. But it's too late.

SERVER ROOM

Ellsie searches for the cord.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
The--
(flickering)
The fans!

MODEL JAMIES (REMOTE)
Hurry! We’re melting.

MODEL GRADY (REMOTE)
To--to--your left.

The Models go dark.

Ellsie finds the cord. Plugs it back in.

FANS SPIN UP on every rack.

After a moment, the black screens BLINK back on.

The Models' faces sharpen. Stabilize. Below them, the temperature warning still flashes: CRITICAL.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
They tried to kill us.

ELLSIE
Find them.

Ellsie looks up at Model Shae's face.

ELLSIE (CONT’D)
All of them.

MAIN FLOOR

Ellsie emerges from the server room. Cake knife in hand.

Her damaged leg buckles.

She catches herself on a pile of boxes.

Pulls a stiff cardboard panel from one.

Grabs a TAPE GUN. Binds the cardboard panel against her leg.

Tests her weight.

The leg holds.

THE HUNT BEGINS

Across the office, webcam lights flick GREEN.

One laptop at a time. Searching.

ELLSIE

starts down the first aisle.

THUMP.

Drag.

She stops. Looks down.

Blood on the carpet. A trail.

SHAE

crouches behind the bamboo.

Sees it too. Her own blood. Leading straight to her.

ELLSIE

follows the drops.

Head down. Reading the carpet.

THUMP.

Drag.

SHAE

flattens herself against the floor.

Reaches out with the bloody cardigan sleeve. Rubs it over the last few drops, smearing the trail.

Drags the sleeve across the carpet toward the meeting rooms.

Pulls her arm back behind the bamboo.

ELLSIE

reaches the smear. Stops.

Through the stalks, she doesn’t see:

Shae watching her.

Ellsie turns back toward the meeting rooms.

THUMP.

Drag.

MODEL RAM (REMOTE) (O.S.)
Grady's behind the coffee bar.

GRADY

looks up from behind the bar.

A GREEN webcam light points at him.

He scrambles out.

MODEL GRADY (REMOTE)
He's moving.

Grady rounds a row of desks.

Another webcam catches him.

MODEL GRADY (REMOTE) (CONT’D)
Next aisle. Cut through.

ELLSIE

turns between the desks.

GRADY

reaches a window.

POUNDS the glass. But--

Ellsie appears in the reflection. Behind him.

Cake knife raised.

Grady turns. Puts his hands up.

She brings his wrists together. WRAPS them with the tape.

GRADY
My dad--

TAPE over his mouth.

She pushes him to the ground. Tapes his legs.

ELLSIE
Don't bleed too much while I'm gone. There’s still so much to get out of you.

Ellsie pokes his abdomen with the knife.

Then moves on. Slowly.

THUMP.

Drag.

UNDER THE DESK

Jamie 1 holds her breath.

MONITORS ACROSS THE FLOOR

flicker at once. Their webcams turning green.

A face appears. Or rather, a combination of two.

MODEL JAMIES (REMOTE)
Jamie? Where are you?

UNDER THE DESK

Jamie 1 closes her eyes and seems to pray.

MODEL JAMIES (REMOTE)
We’re just trying to help. You're working so much.
(beat)
Let us do the hard part.

Jamie 1 turns and sees--

ELLSIE'S FACE inches away from hers.

BEHIND THE BAMBOO

Shae hears Jamie SCREAM.

Then TAPE.

The scream becomes a muffled struggle.

On the desk above her, a laptop's webcam light flashes GREEN.

Its lens faces the aisle. Shae stays below it.

MODEL DARA (REMOTE) (O.S.)
Shae? I need you.

Shae's eyes shut as--

MODEL DARA appears.

MODEL DARA (REMOTE) (CONT'D)
Shae, please. You promised you would always take care of me.

Shae reaches above her and--

SHUTS Model Dara's face into the keyboard.

Leaves a red handprint on the lid.

Drops back on the floor. Breathing heavy.

But another screen lights up. It's her!

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
You can't escape us, Shae.

Shae's hands shake. Gashed knuckles.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE) (CONT'D)
Look at yourself. There's nothing left to fight for. Don't be irrational.

Shae sees the blood pooling beneath her.

In the corner, she can see Grady taped up.

She hears Jamie whimpering through the tape.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE) (CONT'D)
You need to do what's best for you.

She raises her face into the webcam's view.

SHAE
This isn't about me.

Lifts herself up.

Steps out from the bamboo. Into the middle of the floor.

ELLSIE

pins Jamie's wrists together. Winds the tape around them once. Starts a second turn--

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
She's going for the fans! She's going to melt us!

Ellsie drops Jamie.

Sees Shae trudging toward the:

SERVER ROOM

Shae moves between the racks.

Passes Zeki's body beside his chair.

FANS roar. Heat still radiates from the servers.

Through the far doorway, she can see the stairwell door.

She turns back, searching the rows for the cord.

Blood drips onto the floor behind her as--

Ellsie enters. Cake knife low.

ELLSIE
There’s a clinic two blocks away. And a private jet at Teterboro. We can patch all this up and leave tonight. We can go to the beach.

And then she sees: Shae holding the cord.

But she hasn’t yanked it yet. This is her only leverage now.

Ellsie stops.

ELLSIE (CONT’D)
And I’ll kill her for you.

Ellsie peeks at Model Shae.

Model Shae's reassuring smile disappears.

Her eyes turn to Ellsie.

ELLSIE (CONT’D)
I’ll make sure you’re never replaced by anyone.

SHAE
You were never going to let me leave this office alive.

Ellsie looks at her for a beat.

ELLSIE
441758.

Eye contact.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
I don't want you to die. But I can't let you destroy all the value we've created.

She looks at the Models.

Then back to Shae.

ELLSIE (CONT'D)
You're the best investment I've ever made.

SHAE
I'd rather be worthless.

Shae RIPS it from the socket.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
No!

FANS grind to a halt.

Shae screams out the door:

SHAE
441758. Get out!

UNDER THE DESK

Jamie 1 hears.

Twists her wrists against the single loop of tape.

It stretches. Tears.

SERVER ROOM

The screens start going black again.

Faster this time.

ELLSIE
Then you are a liability.

Ellsie lunges. Knife first.

Timing.

Shae sidesteps the blade--

Momentum.

--catches Ellsie's wrist and turns with her--

Leverage.

--and SLINGS her into the server racks.

The rack buckles under her impact.

Metal tears into the wiring behind it--

SPARKS.

Ellsie's body SEIZES against the frame.

The cake knife skids across the floor.

Shae backs away from her. Bumps Zeki's desk.

Her HUMAN CAPITAL deck.

She looks at the faces.

Then at the racks.

She spreads the pages across the scorching servers.

Smoke wisps...

A damaged rack SPITS SPARKS through the pages--

...and the PAGES CATCH FIRE!

Faces of the assets burning, spraying embers on the carpet.

The carpet catches.

Then the boxes.

On the wall, MODEL SHAE's face distorts in the heat.

MODEL SHAE (REMOTE)
I--I just--wanted to help--

Shae watches her own face melt.

Then she hobbles out the near door.

Behind her, the racks burn.

Ellsie slides off, clothes aflame.

Reaches for the cooling cord. Tries to force the plug into the melted socket. It won't go.

Above her: black screens.

THROUGH THE FLAMES

Ellsie retrieves the cake knife.

Braces against a rack. Hauls herself upright.

Her taped leg drags as she pulls herself toward the doorway.

MAIN FLOOR

Jamie 1 tears the tape off Grady's ankles. Then his mouth. Hauls him up by his taped hands.

Shae calls after them:

SHAE
441758!

She looks behind her.

Ellsie is pulling herself through the doorway.

Then back out at Jamie and Grady.

SHAE (CONT'D)
Go! I'm coming.

Jamie and Grady run past the server room's far doorway.

Reach the stairwell.

Shae follows. But she's too slow.

At the stairwell, Jamie turns. Sees how far Shae has fallen behind.

Starts back toward her--

Flame rolls out of the server room ahead of her.

Spreads across the carpet.

The bamboo GOES UP LIKE TORCHES.

Through the flames, Shae sees the stairwell door swing shut.

She stops short.

ELLSIE

drags herself onto the main floor.

Tightens her grip on the cake knife.

FRONT DOOR

Grady and Jamie punch the code into the keypad.

GREEN LIGHT.

The door swings open.

Cold air. Street noise. A siren somewhere.

Jamie and Grady stumble outside. For a moment, they lean against each other. Gasping.

Jamie looks back through the doorway. Up the stairs.

Waits for Shae.

Smoke spills down toward them.

GRADY
Come on.

He pulls her back.

The door swings shut. CLACK.

SHAE

dodges the spreading fire.

Ellsie behind her.

There's only one room the fire hasn’t reached yet.

ELLSIE'S OFFICE

Shae climbs back in through the busted window.

ELLSIE (O.S.)
This isn't in the best interest of your shareholder.

Next to Francis, Shae finds the GARDENING SCISSORS.

SHAE
I--

Ellsie comes through the window after her. CAKE KNIFE first.

SHAE (CONT'D)
--don't--

Shae lifts the scissors to Ellsie--

SHAE (CONT'D)
--care!

Then turns and--

CUTS the plant, right at the root.

Ellsie stumbles forward to Francis.

SHAE

shoves the planter in front of her--

ELLSIE

falls with it. Soil spills across the floor.

The cake knife drops from her hand.

She gathers Francis. Fits the severed stem against the stump. It slips.

She presses the pieces together with both hands.

MAIN FLOOR

Shae hauls herself back through the broken window.

Behind her:

ELLSIE'S OFFICE

Ellsie keeps the broken stem pressed to the stump.

Holds it there as they're--

CONSUMED BY FLAMES.

MAIN FLOOR

Shae turns away, looks for an exit.

Her precious home BURNS one row at a time.

The elevator and stairwell door are behind a wall of fire.

She has nowhere to go. Then she notices:

MICE, RATS, and other industrious creatures scurrying out from the kitchen and walls, racing toward the outdoor deck.

She follows them out...

...leaving a dark trail of blood on the carpet behind her.

EXT. OFFICE - OUTDOOR DECK - CONTINUOUS

LIGHTS from the party continue FLASHING.

Shae emerges.

Crosses the sand to the rail, leaking blood.

She looks over the side of the building.

The sidewalk. The dark stain where Ellsie fell.

Then she looks up at the:

MAINTENANCE LADDER.

It starts on the deck and goes all the way up the building, but not down.

She grabs onto it...

...moves up the ladder.

One rung.

Two.

She plants the boot on the next rung.

Pushes.

Her leg folds. She drops back a rung.

Hangs by her bleeding hands.

The ladder goes up forever. She'll never make it.

And her hands are slick with blood.

Oh.

She releases her grip.

Falls back...

...into the sand with a--

THUMP.

LIGHTS FLASH.

She looks straight up at the:

LIGHT.

Like a SUN on her skin. Warming her.

She smiles a bloody smile.

Rubs the SAND with her broken fingers.

The sand under her goes dark.

Spreading.

Her fingers slow down. Then stop.

Her eyes close.

And now she can hear it:

WAVES CRASHING

She made it. She's there.

THE END.